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Why Your Peptide COA Might Be Fake (And How to Tell)

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The Problem Is Bigger Than You Think

In the research peptide market, a Certificate of Analysis (COA) is supposed to be your guarantee of purity and identity. But the uncomfortable truth is that COA fraud is widespread. Some vendors generate fake COAs in-house, reuse old COAs across different batches, or photoshop results from legitimate labs.

This isn't theoretical. Community testing projects on forums like r/peptides have repeatedly found discrepancies between vendor-provided COAs and independent third-party testing results. Some "99% pure" products have tested below 90%. Others contained the wrong compound entirely.

The 7 Red Flags of a Fake COA

1. No Lab Name or Contact Information

A legitimate COA always identifies the testing laboratory by name, address, and contact information. If the COA has no lab attribution, or lists a vague name you can't verify, it's suspect.

What to look for: Janoshik Analytical, Colmaric Analyticals, and Novascreen Biosciences are the most commonly used third-party labs in the peptide space. You should be able to find the lab's website and verify they exist.

2. No Batch or Lot Number

Every COA should reference a specific batch or lot number that matches the product you received. If the COA has no batch number, or the batch number doesn't match your vial label, the COA may not correspond to your actual product.

3. Suspiciously Round Numbers

Real analytical results have decimal places and minor impurities. A COA showing exactly "99.00%" purity with zero detected impurities is more likely fabricated than one showing "98.73%" with trace impurities identified.

4. Missing HPLC Chromatogram

The HPLC (High-Performance Liquid Chromatography) chromatogram is the actual graph showing the separation of compounds. It's the raw data behind the purity number. A COA without a chromatogram is like a medical test without the actual test results — just a number someone typed.

5. No Mass Spectrometry (MS) Data

Mass spectrometry confirms the molecular identity of the peptide — that it's actually the compound it claims to be, not a cheaper substitute. A COA with HPLC purity but no MS confirmation only tells you something is pure, not what it is.

6. Identical COAs Across Batches

If a vendor provides the exact same COA document for orders placed months apart, they're reusing old results. Legitimate testing produces unique results for each batch, even if purity is similar.

7. The Lab Doesn't Know the Vendor

The ultimate verification: contact the lab listed on the COA and ask if they tested that batch for that vendor. Legitimate labs will confirm or deny. If the lab has no record of the vendor, the COA is fabricated.

How to Verify a COA

1. **Check the lab exists.** Search for the lab name online. Visit their website. Verify they offer peptide testing services.
2. **Match the batch number.** The batch/lot number on the COA should match the label on your product.
3. **Look for the chromatogram.** The HPLC graph should be present and show a clean dominant peak with the retention time labeled.
4. **Verify MS data.** The observed molecular weight should match the expected molecular weight for the peptide (within instrument tolerance, typically ± 1 Da).
5. **Contact the lab.** Email or call the lab with the batch number and ask if they performed the testing. This is the gold standard verification.
6. **Cross-reference with community testing.** Check r/peptides, Peptide Brotherhood, and other communities for independent testing results from the same vendor.

The Vendor Trust Hierarchy

Based on COA practices, vendors generally fall into tiers:

Tier 1 — Consistent third-party COAs: Every batch tested by a named, contactable lab. Chromatograms and MS data included. Lab confirms the relationship. Examples: vendors scoring 80+ on our trust scores.

Tier 2 — Occasional third-party COAs: Some batches tested externally, others tested in-house. Mixed reliability. Verify each batch individually.

Tier 3 — In-house COAs only: All testing done internally with no third-party verification. These COAs are essentially self-reported and should be treated with skepticism.

Tier 4 — No COAs: No testing documentation provided. Avoid entirely.

What About Compounding Pharmacy COAs?

If you're getting peptides through a licensed clinic and compounding pharmacy (the 503A pathway), the quality assurance process is different and generally more reliable:

- 503A pharmacies follow USP standards for compounding
- They source bulk drug substances from FDA-registered suppliers
- Many use PCAB-accredited facilities
- COAs from compounding pharmacies reflect pharmaceutical-grade sourcing

This is one of the key advantages of the prescription pathway over research vendors. See our guide on [503A vs 503B pharmacies](#) for more context.

The Bottom Line

A COA is only as trustworthy as the lab that produced it and the vendor that provides it. Don't take COAs at face value — verify the lab, check the data, and when in doubt, contact the lab directly. Your health depends on it.

For a step-by-step guide to reading COA data, see our companion article: [How to Read a Certificate of Analysis](#).



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